UNIT 5 · TOPIC 5.2

Protecting Applications and Data: Managerial Controls and Access Controls

Assignment

Instructions: 12 practice questions + 3 coding assignment(s), 27 points total. Show your work for short-answer items. Coding assignments may be completed here or in the interactive auto-graded environment on the course site (same problem, same points).

Name: **Date:** **Class:**

Practice Questions

5.2.a · Access control models (RBAC, DAC, MAC)

1. In Unix, a file's owner sets read/write/execute permissions for owner, group, and others. Which access control model does this describe? (1 pt)

- ○ A. Discretionary Access Control (DAC)
- ○ B. Mandatory Access Control (MAC)
- ○ C. Role-Based Access Control (RBAC)
- ○ D. Attribute-Based Access Control (ABAC)

2. Select ALL statements that correctly describe Mandatory Access Control (MAC). (3 pts)

- □ A. A central policy authority assigns labels to subjects and objects
- □ B. Individual object owners can freely grant access to anyone they choose
- □ C. The system enforces label-based rules automatically, regardless of owner preference
- □ D. MAC originated in government/military contexts (e.g., Bell-LaPadula)

(Select ALL that apply.)

3. A hospital assigns permissions to a 'Nurse' role and a 'Billing Clerk' role rather than to each of its 5,000 staff individually. Which model is this? (1 pt)

- ○ A. DAC
- ○ B. MAC
- ○ C. RBAC
- ○ D. None of these

4. Name the design principle: grant each subject only the permissions needed to do its job, nothing more. (1 pt)

5.2.b · Roles, permissions, and least privilege

5. What is the principle that a subject should be granted only the permissions it needs to do its job, nothing more? (1 pt)

- ○ A. Least privilege

○ B. Separation of duties

○ C. Role recertification

○ D. Mandatory access control

6. Select ALL statements that correctly describe privilege creep. (3 pts)

□ A. It is the gradual, unnoticed accumulation of unnecessary permissions over time

□ B. It happens because missing permissions are loudly noticed and fixed, while excess permissions are silently ignored

□ C. It is prevented automatically by RBAC with no further effort

□ D. Periodic role review/recertification is used to counteract it

(Select ALL that apply.)

7. Why should the person who creates a vendor payment not also be the person who approves it? (1 pt)

○ A. Separation of duties requires that a sensitive process need collusion between two people to be abused

○ B. It violates least privilege by definition

○ C. Payments cannot be created and approved by the same software

○ D. It is a MAC labeling requirement

8. Name the metaphor used to describe how much damage a compromised account with excess permissions can do. (1 pt)

5.2.c · Credential theft prevention and lateral movement

9. An attacker who compromises one marketing laptop uses stolen credentials to hop to several other internal machines in search of valuable systems. What is this process called? (1 pt)

○ A. Lateral movement

○ B. Cross-site scripting

○ C. Broken object level authorization

○ D. Data exfiltration

10. Select ALL statements that correctly describe pass-the-hash / pass-the-ticket attacks. (3 pts)

□ A. The attacker authenticates using a stolen hash or ticket without ever knowing the plaintext password

□ B. These attacks require the attacker to crack the password first

□ C. They exploit authentication protocols that accept hash- or ticket-based authentication

□ D. Multi-factor authentication significantly reduces the impact of a successfully stolen credential

(Select ALL that apply.)

11. Why does reusing the same local administrator password across every machine in an organization make lateral movement much easier for an attacker? (1 pt)

○ A. It has no effect on lateral movement

○ B. Shared passwords are always encrypted differently on each machine

○ C. One stolen admin credential authenticates on every machine that shares it, removing the need to steal new credentials at each hop

○ D. It only affects DAC systems

12. Name one behavioral signal defenders watch for that suggests an account is engaged in lateral movement (e.g., unusually high count of what). (1 pt)

Coding Assignments (Python 3)

5.2.a · Access control models (RBAC, DAC, MAC)

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem, 5.2.a: RBAC / DAC / MAC access decision

Skill: Mitigate Risk · **Maps to:** 5.2.A · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build the access-decision function a policy engine would run for a fictional file system that supports all three access control models. Given a request (subject, object, action, and the object's model), decide whether the request is ALLOWed or DENYed.

Rules by model

- **`"dac"`**, allowed if the subject is the object's `owner`, OR the subject appears in the object's `grants` list for that action (e.g., `grants: {"read": ["bob"], "write": []}`).
- **`"mac"`**, allowed only if the subject's clearance level is >= the object's classification level. Levels (low to high): `"public"` < `"confidential"` < `"secret"` < `"top_secret"`.
- **`"rbac"`**, allowed if any of the subject's `roles` is present in the object's `allowed_roles` list for the requested action (e.g., `allowed_roles: {"read": ["nurse","admin"], "write": ["admin"]}`).

If the object's `model` is not one of `"dac"`, `"mac"`, `"rbac"`, deny with reason `"unknown_model"`.

Function contract

Implement `solve(request: dict) -> dict` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

`request`: a dict with keys `"subject"` (dict) and `"object"` (dict) and `"action"` (str). See `interface.md` for the exact shape per model.

Output

`{"allowed": bool, "reason": str}` where reason is one of `"owner"`, `"granted"`, `"dac_denied"`, `"clearance_sufficient"`, `"clearance_insufficient"`, `"role_match"`, `"rbac_denied"`, `"unknown_model"`.

Examples

```
DAC owner:
  {"subject":{"name":"alice"},"object":{"model":"dac","owner":"alice","grants":{}},"action":"read"}
  -> {"allowed": True, "reason": "owner"}

MAC insufficient clearance:
  {"subject":{"clearance":"confidential"},"object":{"model":"mac","classification":"secret"},"action":"read"}
  -> {"allowed": False, "reason": "clearance_insufficient"}

RBAC role match:
```

```
{"subject":{"roles":["nurse"]},"object":{"model":"rbac","allowed_roles":{"read":["nurse","admin"]}},"action":"read"}
  -> {"allowed": True, "reason": "role_match"}
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.2.a. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import Dict


def solve(request: Dict[str, object]) -> Dict[str, object]:
    """Decide ALLOW/DENY for a DAC, MAC, or RBAC access request.

    Args:
        request: {"subject": dict, "object": dict, "action": str}
    Returns:
        {"allowed": bool, "reason": str} per the rules in prompt.md / interface.md.
    """
    # TODO: branch on request["object"]["model"] ("dac" | "mac" | "rbac") and apply
    #       the corresponding rule from prompt.md. Unknown model -> "unknown_model".
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```

5.2.b · Roles, permissions, and least privilege

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem, 5.2.b: Detect least-privilege violations

Skill: Mitigate Risk · **Maps to:** 5.2.A, 5.2.B · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build the audit function a security reviewer would run over a company's role assignments. Given a map of roles to the permissions they grant, a map of users to their assigned roles, and a map of users to the minimum permission set their job function actually requires, find every user who holds at least one permission (via their assigned roles) that is NOT in their job function's required set.

Function contract

Implement `solve(roles: dict, user_roles: dict, job_requirements: dict) -> dict` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

- `roles`: `dict[str, list[str]]`, role name -> list of permissions it grants.
- `user_roles`: `dict[str, list[str]]`, user name -> list of role names assigned to them.
- `job_requirements`: `dict[str, list[str]]`, user name -> list of permissions their job function actually requires.

Output

A dict mapping each violating user to the **sorted** list of their excess (unauthorized) permissions. Users with no excess permissions are omitted entirely from the result.

Examples

```
roles = {"support": ["read_ticket", "write_ticket_reply"], "billing": ["read_invoice", "issue_refund"]}
user_roles = {"dana": ["support", "billing"]}
job_requirements = {"dana": ["read_ticket", "write_ticket_reply"]}

solve(roles, user_roles, job_requirements)
-> {"dana": ["issue_refund", "read_invoice"]}
```

```
roles = {"support": ["read_ticket"]}
user_roles = {"sam": ["support"]}
job_requirements = {"sam": ["read_ticket"]}

solve(roles, user_roles, job_requirements)
-> {}
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- A user with roles granting no permissions beyond their job requirements is omitted from the output entirely (not included with an empty list).
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.2.b. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import Dict, List


def solve(
    roles: Dict[str, List[str]],
    user_roles: Dict[str, List[str]],
    job_requirements: Dict[str, List[str]],
) -> Dict[str, List[str]]:
    """Flag users whose role-derived permissions exceed their job requirements.

    Args:
        roles: role name -> list of permissions it grants.
        user_roles: user name -> list of role names assigned to them.
        job_requirements: user name -> list of permissions their job requires.
    Returns:
        dict of user -> sorted list of excess (unauthorized) permissions.
        Users with no excess permissions are omitted entirely.
    """
    # TODO: for each user, union the permissions of their assigned roles, subtract
    #       their job_requirements, and include them in the result only if the
    #       excess set is non-empty (sorted list).
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```

5.2.c · Credential theft prevention and lateral movement

3 pts · auto-graded on the site

Coding problem, 5.2.c: Detect lateral movement in an authentication log

Skill: Mitigate Risk, Detect Attacks · **Maps to:** 5.2.B, 5.2.C · **Language:** Python 3 (pytest)

Problem

Build the detector a security team's SIEM rule would run over authentication events. Given a list of authentication events (account, destination host, timestamp in minutes), flag any account that authenticated to **at least `threshold` distinct hosts** within any rolling **`window_minutes`** window, a classic lateral-movement signal.

Function contract

Implement `solve(events: list, threshold: int, window_minutes: int) -> list` in `starter.py` (see `interface.md` / `blackbox.yaml`).

Input

- `events`: `list[dict]`, each `{"account": str, "host": str, "ts": int}` (`ts` = minutes since start of log, non-negative integer, not necessarily sorted).
- `threshold`: `int`, minimum number of **distinct** hosts within the window to flag the account.
- `window_minutes`: `int`, size of the rolling time window, in minutes (inclusive on both ends).

Output

A **sorted, de-duplicated** `list[str]` of account names that hit the threshold at any point.

Examples

```
events = [
  {"account":"mkt_dana","host":"h1","ts":0},
  {"account":"mkt_dana","host":"h2","ts":2},
  {"account":"mkt_dana","host":"h3","ts":4},
  {"account":"svc_backup","host":"h9","ts":0},
]
solve(events, threshold=3, window_minutes=5) -> ["mkt_dana"]
```

```
events = [
  {"account":"alice","host":"h1","ts":0},
  {"account":"alice","host":"h2","ts":100},
]
solve(events, threshold=2, window_minutes=5) -> []   # too far apart for the window
```

Constraints

- Deterministic, offline, standard library only.
- A window `[t, t + window_minutes]` counts an event if its `ts` falls within that inclusive range; consider every event's `ts` as a possible window start.
- Repeated authentications to the SAME host do not add distinct-host count.
- Must pass all cases in `tests.py` (visible + hidden).

How to run

```
cd problem && python -m pytest tests.py -q
```

Starter code:

```
"""Starter code for 5.2.c. Student completes the TODO.
This file intentionally FAILS the tests until implemented."""
from typing import Dict, List


def solve(events: List[Dict[str, object]], threshold: int, window_minutes: int) -> List[str]:
    """Flag accounts whose authentication events hit >= threshold distinct hosts
    within some rolling window of `window_minutes`.

    Args:
        events: list of {"account": str, "host": str, "ts": int}
        threshold: minimum distinct-host count within the window to flag an account
        window_minutes: size of the inclusive rolling window, in minutes
    Returns:
        sorted, de-duplicated list[str] of flagged account names.
    """
    # TODO: group events by account; for each account, for every event's ts as a
    #       candidate window start, count distinct hosts with ts in [start, start+window_minutes];
    #       flag the account if any window reaches `threshold`.
    raise NotImplementedError("implement solve() — see prompt.md")
```